



The Moral Image of Work

Introduction

Theme: Food, Domesticity and Labor

Focus: How artists show everyday work as dignity and care.

Overview

Today we look at two painters who turn kitchen work into something almost sacred:

- **Johannes Vermeer, *The Milkmaid*** — a woman pouring milk in a quiet room.
 - Attached Reading: The Painter in his Studio
- **Diego Velázquez, *Kitchen Scene with Christ in the House of Martha and Mary*** — a servant in a kitchen, with a small religious scene in the background.

Both ask how simple acts of preparing food can carry **moral and spiritual weight**.

Learning Objectives

- Notice how light, gesture, and composition give importance to domestic labor.
- Discuss how work in the kitchen can be seen as devotion and care.
- Connect Berger's ideas about "the eaters and the eaten" to these images.

Activities

1. Opening Reflection

Read a short line from Berger, such as:

"The sharing of bread was once a pledge that all would live."

Write: When someone prepares food for you, what are they giving you besides just food?

2. Study 1 – Vermeer, *The Milkmaid*

Look closely at the painting.

- Where does the light fall?
- What is the woman doing, exactly?
- How do color, texture, and stillness make her work feel important or calm?

3. Study 2 – Velázquez, *Kitchen Scene with Christ in the House of Martha and Mary*

Look at the kitchen and the figures.

- What is happening in the foreground vs. the background?
- How does the servant's work relate to the small scene with Christ and Mary?
- What does this say about the value of ordinary labor?

4. Compare and Discuss

- How do Vermeer and Velázquez each show **respect** for domestic workers?
- Where do you see hints of **religion**, **ethics**, or **care**?
- How do these paintings change the way we might look at someone cooking or cleaning?

5. Class Reflection

Share one sentence that starts:

"Everyday work becomes important when..."

Question

How do Vermeer and Velázquez turn everyday kitchen work into an image of moral or spiritual care?

Key Idea

Domestic labor is not just background.

Through light and attention, artists can show it as a **moral act**, full of dignity and care.

The Painter in his Studio